

keyboard has standard one-touch hotkeys for multimedia and Internet applications.

Zebronics' ZEB-K500L was the odd one out in this, the stand-alone keyboard category. It is designed to be a slim keyboard, and hence is small and cramped. However, the translucent casing gives it a chic look. It also features a blue backlight, but the white-on-black letters are hard to read in poor lighting conditions, even with the backlight on. Thankfully, there's also a switch using which you can turn off the backlight when it becomes unbearable.

The same design is also available as the ZEB-K500, which has a white translucent body and no backlight.

The Genius SlimStar, as the name suggests, is a slim keyboard that's flat and sleek. Overall, it looks great. It features 12 hotkeys for controlling multimedia applications and Internet functions.

The strong point, however, of this keyboard is its designer

looks; sadly, the same cannot be said about its features. Genius' other entry, the LuxeMate Scroll keyboard, is great as far as looks and product quality are concerned. There is hardly any space between the keys, and it looks like a laptop keypad.

BenQ's A110 is another stylish keyboard that could win an award for design. This keyboard is milky white, and has the looks to entice any buyer, but in terms of features, it's just a vanilla keyboard, and is devoid of any frills.



iBall Power key Designer

Ergonomics

No other keyboard comes close to the ergonomics of Logitech's keyboards. Both the Standard Classic keyboard and the G5 gaming keyboard set the standards for others to emulate. The G5 offers better comfort and uses better materials, and while the entry-level standard keyboard may be devoid of plush feel materials, it still offers the same true tactile feedback necessary for touch-typing. Logitech's Internet keyboard somehow doesn't feel the same; the keys are too soft and often miss keystrokes.

The iBall Power Key Designer comes out good on our ergonomic scale due to its excellent key feedback—it's just a shade behind the Logitech standard keyboard. Also, the placement of the buttons with respect to the home keys is excellent, and reaching them requires minimal stretching of the fingers.

The Tech-Com SSD-KB-990 and SSD-KB-880 have just one

How We Tested

Keyboards Features

Number of keys: This count reflects the number of hotkeys provided with the keyboard, apart from the standard keys it had. These hotkeys included the multimedia keys, Internet keys, etc.

Batteries required: Cordless keyboards require alkaline batteries to run, and we logged the type and number of batteries required. If a keyboard uses AA batteries, the running costs are cheaper compared to keyboards that use AAA batteries. Also, fewer batteries result in lower running costs.

Miscellaneous features: Unique features that deserve attention were logged under this field. Features such as a scroll wheel, direction pad, backlight on/off switch, slots on the bottom of the keyboard for proper wire management, buttons for zoom, etc., were logged here.

Ergonomics

Keys: With respect to the keys, we logged the spacing between the keys, key layout, size of specific keys such as [Enter], [Insert] etc., and, most importantly, the tactile feel they provided. Too soft and too mushy a feel was rated low.

Miscellaneous: Parameters such as the comfort of the palm rest, elevation of the keyboard before and after using the foot pegs, etc., were logged on a scale of five.

Performance

We typed, 10 times, the standard "The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog," changing the case to UPPER, lower and Sentence. Then we typed all the numbers and special characters. We used the [Home], [End] and [Delete] keys, and tried the [Page up] and [Page down] keys as well.

Finally, to get a proper feel of the keyboard, we typed a paragraph of around 250 words using each keyboard.

Mice

Mice were evaluated on the following parameters.

Design: An ambidextrous design allows the mouse to be used by left-handed people.

Wired/Cordless: Cordless mice are great for the degree of freedom they allow when working. For daily use, we recommend cordless mice; however, if you are a gamer, the lag associated with cordless mice might not work in your favour—you should choose something like the Logitech G7 gaming mouse instead.

Sensor used: Here we logged the tracking engine used, which includes ball technology, standard LED optics or high-precision laser. The sensitivity and accuracy of the mice decrease in the order of Laser-LED optics-Ball.

Miscellaneous features: Features such as horizontal scrolling, a power switch, a portable USB receiver in the case of notebook mice, and the mouse interface were also logged.

Physical characteristics: Grip, placement of buttons, scroll wheel placement, weight of the mouse, gliding efficiency, etc. indicate the comfort level a user will experience.

Action feedback: Parameters such as the tactile feel the buttons provide, the feel associated with the scroll wheel, etc., were logged.

Performance: For evaluating the performance of the mouse, we used it for two successive rounds of Quake III's DM17 map. The first round was played at 1204 x 768, and the second round was played at 1280 x 1024, to check the difference in sensitivity and the subsequent effect on accuracy.